

STRIP-AND-ENDPLAY

South opens 1♠, partnership reaches 4♠.

Teaching feature: declarer faces a critical loser problem in one side suit (typically clubs). Rather than finessing for the Q, declarer can STRIP the other suits, then throw East in with a heart and force East to lead into declarer's club tenace.

Holdings:

- Spades — 5-3 fit with solid honors.
- Hearts — declarer has AKx (or similar) opposite small; can play two rounds to exhaust East, then throw the third round to East.
- Diamonds — declarer cashes A and K, ruffs the third in dummy if needed.
- Clubs — AJx opposite Kxx, with the Q missing. The 50% finesse can be avoided entirely by the endplay.

The plan:

1. Win the opening lead.
2. Draw two rounds of trump (don't draw all — you may need a trump entry).
3. Cash AK of diamonds; ruff the third diamond in dummy.
4. Cash AK of hearts.
5. Lead a third heart to East.
6. East must return either a club (into your AJ tenace — J wins) or give you a ruff-and-discard. Either way, you don't lose a club trick.

Things to think about:

- Why do you NOT take the club finesse?
- What if East has shorter clubs than expected?
- How do you keep the trumps you need to recover from each ruff?

Reference: <https://www.bridgebum.com/endplay.php>